Forge Viral Discovery Summary — 2026-05-11

Scope: TARGETED — friend's existing project **AXEL** (roguelite slot, Moon Princess 100 mechanics reskin).

Discovery Statistics

- Trends analyzed: 10 (focused on slot-roguelite sub-genre)
- Concepts reframed: 1 (AXEL core)
- Variations generated: 5
- Solo-buildable (Tier 1–2): 3
- Small-team opportunities (Tier 3): 1
- Skip (Tier 4–5): 1
- Master prompts created: 3

Headline Finding

The cascading-cluster slot mechanic (NetEnt/Moon Princess lineage) is **unoccupied in the roguelite frame**. CloverPit (100k copies day-1) took the 1-armed-bandit angle. Luck Be a Landlord took single-spin symbols. Cascadou took cards. **The grid-cascade-cluster route is the open lane right now**, and AXEL is already targeting it. Build window: 6–12 weeks.

Top Solo-Build Recommendations

#1: AXEL: ZERO (validation prototype)

- **Score:** V7.0 × B9.0 × M5.5 → Combined 7.2
- **Team:** Solo
- **Source ridden:** Moon Princess 100 cascade mechanics + Balatro/CloverPit zeitgeist
- **Build:** 1–2 weeks
- **Decision:** BUILD NOW
- **Prompt:** `master-prompts/game-1-axel-zero.md`

#2: AXEL: Resonance (full release)

- **Score:** V8.0 × B6.5 × M7.0 → Combined 7.3
- **Team:** Solo (vector art, no commission)
- **Build:** 3–4 weeks (after ZERO validates)
- **Decision:** BUILD
- **Prompt:** `master-prompts/game-2-axel-resonance.md`

#3: AXEL: Tilt (narrative alternative)

- **Score:** V8.0 × B5.5 × M7.0 → Combined 6.9
- **Team:** Solo+
- **Build:** 4–6 weeks
- **Decision:** BUILD if narrative angle tests stronger
- **Prompt:** `master-prompts/game-3-axel-tilt.md`

Small Team Opportunity

Name	V	B	Combined	Why Team Needed
AXEL: Grease	8.0	4.5	6.5	Pixel artist required for CloverPit-zeitgeist aesthetic

Critical IP Note

AXEL's spec currently references "Moon Princess 100" mechanics, "princess powers", and "Trinity meter". **All naming and visuals must be reframed** before public marketing. Mechanics themselves (cluster pays, cascade, multiplier wild, grid-clear free spins) are non-copyrightable industry standards. Full safe-reframe achievable with zero loss to viral appeal. See `03-reframing.md`.

All Variations Quick Reference

Tier	Count	Decision
1 - BUILD NOW	2	AXEL: ZERO + AXEL: Resonance
2 - BUILD	1	AXEL: Tilt (alt narrative)
3 - SMALL TEAM	1	AXEL: Grease (needs pixel artist)
4 - SKIP	1	AXEL: Sigil (saturated fantasy lane)

Action Items

- [ ] Share this discovery folder with friend (the AXEL owner)
- [ ] Friend reviews `checkpoint.md` and answers open questions:
    - Pixel artist access?
    - Web prototype (ZERO) first, or skip to Steam?
    - Cosmic (Resonance) vs heist (Tilt) theme?
    - Platform priority?
- [ ] Friend renames "Trinity meter" + drops "Moon Princess" references in any existing AXEL docs
- [ ] Start `master-prompts/game-1-axel-zero.md` in a fresh Claude Code session in a new project folder
- [ ] After 1–2 weeks: launch ZERO, measure K-factor, decide on Resonance vs Tilt

Wave Riding Notes

- **Current hottest trend:** Roguelite slot machines (CloverPit's 100k-day shipped recently; KEEP GAMBLING, Slots & Daggers, Slot & Dungeons, Runeborn all rising in 2026)
- **Build window:** 6–12 weeks before the cascading-cluster sub-niche specifically gets crowded
- **Kill criteria:** ZERO K-factor < 0.3 for 2 weeks → pivot directly to full release OR rethink hook
- **Continue criteria:** ZERO K > 0.5 → start Resonance immediately